FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

There seems to be a kind of internal life force that propels the BJP. An appetite for ceaseless growth and domination—a raging fire in the belly—that is absent in the others, most conspicuously in the Congress. On March 10, 2022, on the evening of another stunning set of victories in assembly elections, the state Prime Minister Narendra Modi took care to talk about was Punjab—the only one out of five where the BJP had come up short. That inner drive could not have been better expressed. For the BJP under Modi, failure only carves out a future project for success, a call to redoubled action. The sense the party exudes is that of an unstoppable force. It is as if the Indian landscape itself is readjusting itself in a more rightward space to accommodate it.

Uttar Pradesh has spoken. The message of the 'double-engine sarkar'—Modi+Yogi, which was propagated aggressively in the election campaign—has yielded bountiful results for the BJP. This was despite a host of perceived negative factors. Farmer anger, joblessness, the devastation wrought by Covid and the problem of stray cattle were all outweighed by the positive buzz created by the double-engine formula. India's politically most dominant state has given us what is now another undeniable presence, that of Yogi Adityanath, who came to be known in the election campaign as 'Bulldozer Baba' because of his strong stand on law and order. Well, this monk created history by practically driving 38 million voters straight to the polling booth with a single wish: to vote BJP. That's nearly 9 million more than what the Samajwadi Party managed. In the process, Yogi has become the first chief minister of UP ever to be re-elected after a full term in office. The results validate the findings of the India Today-Axis My India exit poll. People chose 'development' as their number one reason for going with the BJP—highways are a visible index of that, not an abstract reality but one within the individual voter's lived experience. So are the second and third reasons: law and order and welfare schemes. Free rations, flowing from a policy idea crafted by Amit Shah, have played an undeniable role in placating voter ire on other fronts, and a sense of security is simply one of those most basic aspects of everyday life—it has elements that surpass the communal. What the Modi regime does extremely well is drill home the message of development while managing the caste equations at the micro level. What we are seeing, in reality, is the birth of a new constituency of voters who are the beneficiaries of welfarism, mainly the poor. It's a constituency that overrides caste, with an underpinning of Hindutva. The women, in particular, are part of this new vote bank.



June 3, 2019



February 7, 2022

Voters in four other states have also spoken. The story here is indisputably Brand Modi. The aura that Modi lends to the BJP is that of a phenomenal vote-catcher. In Uttarakhand or Goa, for instance, the chief ministerial face made no difference—in fact, it hardly mattered that the incumbent may have been weak or, indeed, a liability. Both states were seen to be beset with problems and voter anger. Beginning from exactly March 10 last year, the hill state has seen three CMs—and with Pushkar Dhami losing his personal contest, it may see a fourth. Will Dhami or Goa CM Pramod Sawant be back or not? It is nearly immaterial.

The woeful state of the party the BJP has supplanted in the role of the 'natural party of governance', the Congress, is nowhere more starkly manifest than in Manipur, where the victorious chief minister, N. Biren Singh, and a dozen winning candidates of the BJP are former members of the INC. That is the reason why these results carry a lot more weight than just what they mean for these individual states. The momentum for 2024 is firmly set. The fate of Akhilesh Yadav—who gave the fight of his life and came up with his party's best-ever vote share at 32.1 per cent, and yet faced that massive deficit in overall numbers—holds ominous lessons for the Opposition. In our main essay, Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa examines how a national climate has been set by these results. The internal dynamics of the BJP are also interesting to watch here, with the rise of Yogi.

The other stunning story is, of course, Punjab and the way the Aam Aadmi Party has created a new narrative of anti-elitism. On the battlefield lie the bruised egos of all manner of traditional politicians, trounced by total newcomers, salt of the earth. Arvind Kejriwal is now the only non-BJP, non-Congress figure with two states under his control—even if Delhi is only 'half a state', it has a salience much beyond its size or governance structure. What does this mean for the future trajectory of India's politics? With the simultaneous decline in Congress's fortunes, there is talk of AAP becoming 'the alternative'. Of course, the party is nowhere near the ecstatic heights it registered a decade ago, but it has clawed its way back into contention. Deputy Editor Kaushik Deka discusses the long way it has to travel—India still lies ahead of AAP as a largely unknown truth.

It is increasingly clear as we approach the 11 state elections left to go in the run-up to the general election of 2024 that we reside in what we had described in our cover story dated June 3, 2019, after the BJP's re-election at the Centre, as The Republic of Modi. At the moment, it seems it is the age of TIMO. There is Modi Only.



(Aroon Purie)